

Universal Protocol: Prevention of Wrong-Site, Wrong-Procedure, and Wrong-Person Surgery

Policy Number	POL-SURG-007	Owner / Department	Perioperative Services / Patient Safety
Effective Date	2023-03-15	Version	3.0
Last Revised	2026-02-20	Next Review	2028-02-20
Approved By	Patient Safety & Quality Committee	Applies To	All operative and invasive procedures, in any setting (OR, procedural, bedside)

1. Purpose

To prevent wrong-site, wrong-procedure, and wrong-person events through the three components of The Joint Commission Universal Protocol: pre-procedure verification, site marking, and a time-out.

2. Policy — Three Required Components

- 1. Pre-procedure verification.** Confirm the correct patient (two identifiers), correct procedure, and correct site, and that all relevant documents, consent, images, and required equipment/implants are present and matched.
- 2. Site marking.** The licensed provider performing the procedure marks the site, involving the patient when possible, for any procedure with laterality, multiple structures, or multiple levels. The mark must be unambiguous and remain visible after prep and draping.
- 3. Time-out.** Immediately before incision/start, the entire team pauses and actively verbally confirms, at a minimum, correct patient identity, correct site, and correct procedure. The time-out is documented.

3. Severity & Reporting

IMPORTANT — A wrong-site, wrong-procedure, or wrong-person event is a Serious Reportable Event and a sentinel event — always SEV-1. If recognized at any point, stop immediately, stabilize the patient, and notify the surgeon of record, the Administrator-on-Call, and Risk Management at once. Manage per POL-RM-004 (RCA² within 45 business days).

4. Documentation Requirements

- Completed pre-procedure verification checklist and consent.
- Site mark and the name of the provider who marked it.
- Time-out performed, participants, and confirmation of patient/site/procedure.
- Any discrepancy identified and how it was resolved before proceeding.

5. References

- The Joint Commission, Universal Protocol (UP.01.01.01, UP.01.02.01, UP.01.03.01).

- The Joint Commission, NPSG.01.01.01 — two patient identifiers.
- Related: POL-PS-008, POL-RM-004, POL-RM-013.